

Transition to Modernity – European Nationalism Encounters North American Nations

While it is true that Peter Fidler's travel journals give us an exemplary eye-witness account of the native peoples of Canada at the very moment of European contact, they also give us a singularly insightful view of European people at the moment of a radical transformation; a view that is all the more valuable for being contrasted with pre-contact North American peoples. Fidler lived during the period when the people of England transformed their social anchor, the basis of trust that allows humans to live as part of a social group, from the relatively small groups that humanity had known since the formation of the species in Africa, to the cities of strangers that define the era of modernity. Although cities had been changing the world for several millennia prior to the onset of industrialization, the ancient and early-modern cities were very different places than those that formed in early-industrial England as rural workers were forced to move to the cities without their own people and take up residence among strangers.

This transition from people who lived with, and belonged to, a small group of people from birth to death, to individuals who could live with, trust, and be trusted by, people who did not belong to a small and relatively static group, was perhaps the most significant change in human behavior in the history of the species. Although the change was initiated by early industrialization, the change in outlook was the crucial factor that allowed the industrial revolution to actually work. Without a social anchor, humans cannot extend trust to one another and thus cooperative behavior becomes impossible. An industrial society is one in which strangers must be able to communicate with each other, work together in complicated webs of coordinated activity, and most importantly, live with each other knowing that each person can sleep soundly at night without fearing for their personal safety. The social anchor of the small, lifetime group was based on the trust that comes from knowing and interacting with the same small group of people throughout life, of developing bespoke mental models of each individual in the group that allows each member of the group to predict and understand the behavior of each other member. The proto-nationalism that developed during early industrialization in England was based on the development of an archetypal mental model of other people within the developing notion of a "national" identity. The language, lifestyle, customs, religion, dress, songs and dances, celebrations, and ways of understanding how a person should live their life were all similar enough in this time and place so that a common identity could just begin to be imagined and used to predict the behavior of strangers. The transition was not abrupt, taking several generations of people born into, and raised within, the emerging identity before it could become a true replacement for the social anchor of the home group of a village. Industrialization and the proto-nationalism of learning to live with strangers were mutually reinforcing feedback systems that eventually created the nationalisms that spread through Europe organically and later became adopted elsewhere as officially imposed polities.

This is not the typical view of how nationalism, and the resulting national identities, developed. Ernest Gellner comes closest, with his explanation of how the needs of industry—literate and numerate workers who could cooperate with strangers—was the critical factor. Benedict Anderson takes up the story of how growing literacy fed back into print capitalism to develop national identities through the imagined communities that are the focus of local newspapers, pamphlets, and novels. However, these mechanisms, though certainly important, assume that there was no essential difficulty for individuals to leave their home groups and join the multitudes of strangers moving to the cities to make a living out of labouring for wages or food and shelter. The hellish miseries of the mills were assumed to arise purely as a result of the ruthless capitalists taking every inch of life from the unfortunate workers in search of profit and competitive advantage. I propose that a great deal of their suffering was a result of not having a social anchor within the forced and unnatural communal squats that they had to seek shelter in.

I believe that this need for belongingness is overlooked because it largely exists as an emotional bond, cultivated by the care and attention given first by parents, then family, and ultimately by one's

community as we grow into adult humans. Thus when it goes missing, if, for example, we are thrust into a group of strangers, we feel an emotional emptiness but we have no intellectual method for identifying the cause of our distress. Belonging to a group is built using the cultural techniques of emotional resonance such as ritual, rhythm, song, dance, synchronized actions, and other coordinated social activities that stimulate a deep emotional reaction. As children participate in these events, they tend to introduce minor changes here and there (children learn about the world through experimentation; it is the most natural thing in the world to play with conventions and observe the consequences). When one of these changes becomes adopted by their peers, an intense emotional charge flows through the group of youngsters as they begin to create their own variant of social reality. Language, as just one example, slowly evolves as children create slang terms that occasionally become part of the vernacular. The modification (and even creation) of the social reality of a particular group by children growing up as part of that group imprints itself as a social anchor of the group—each child has an emotional attachment to a shared group identity. They understand that everyone within the group shares that identity and their individuality is merely a variation on that identity.

The foundation of developing a national identity at the onset of industrialization was, therefore, the development of a standardized educational system. This allowed the imprinting of a “national” identity on children that could potentially encompass all the strangers that they would interact with in the growing cities, pulling them in to a home group that was greatly expanded. In England, the language, customs, dress, religion, and other cultural behaviors were already close enough that this process was mostly one of finding a median path and swamping out all the regional variations as each succeeding generation adopted the centralized customs that they had participated in while growing up. In other parts of Europe, where state boundaries encompassed much more diverse cultural identities, a national identity was much more of an artificial creation, imposed on the population through standardized educational systems and propaganda. From there, the forces of industrialization, the economic discipline of market capitalism, and the ideological continuity of print capitalism cemented these imagined communities into national identities.

Peter Fidler’s travel journals show us an individual who grew up in England during the height of this radical transformation as he interacts with peoples who are firmly ensconced within the ancient human environment of the life-long home group. Both of these social and economic contexts are utterly foreign to us, although we are likely to see through Fidler’s eyes as if they were our own. This would be a mistake not only because we might make incorrect inferences about the native viewpoints, but also because we would miss the opportunity to better understand the social and economic upheavals that shaped our own society.

Economically, Fidler was born at the tail end of the transition to market capitalism in England. Starting in the mid 1500s, as the “great rebuilding” spread throughout England, the populace was transformed from peasant subsistence agriculture to primarily specialized workers who had to look to the market to obtain the food and goods needed to survive. This, too, was a slow and painful transition that was accompanied by a great deal of suffering and misery. Throughout the 1600s, there was nowhere near enough money in circulation to account for the economic transactions that took place. Most people had very little money, and only held it for a short time. There was no practical way to save money, nor was there any social inclination to do so. The economy was based on credit; everyone from the poor to the wealthy had to receive credit to make purchases, and extend credit to make sales. Money was very important as a unit of account (a way of measuring the relative value of goods and services) but less important as a medium of exchange (being based on precious metals, whose value came from scarcity, coined money was by definition a scarce commodity).

In this economy of obligation, trust and personal reputation were the defining qualities that measured an individual’s sense of worth. The growing economy created the conditions for more people to abandon

subsistence agriculture and specialize in manufacturing goods or providing services and then going to the market to purchase the necessities of life. However the need to obtain and extend credit prevented any individual from straying beyond a small group of tradesmen. The need for trust meant that long-term personal interaction with any given buyer or seller was a pre-requisite for obtaining or extending credit since one's very life depended on maintaining a reputation for always meeting one's obligations. Any credit networks that extended beyond the bounds of personal trust were necessarily fraught with the danger that a single default could bring the whole network down in a domino-effect crash. There simply wasn't the abundance of food and necessities that we know today and so there was very little margin for supporting those who fell into default through either circumstance or personal shortcomings.

The growing economy meant that credit networks inevitably expanded beyond what could safely be vouchsafed by personal interactions. As a result, the amount of litigation over unpaid debts climbed to astronomical levels (every household in England was involved in, on average, one litigation per year by the mid-to-late 1600s). Eventually institutional solutions caught up to the expanding crises of market capitalism. Better bankruptcy laws, safe investments such as the Bank of England, the expanding use of IOUs issued by wealthy merchants as a form of exchangeable paper money, an ethic of saving money before spending, and other societal innovations removed much of the stress and anxiety faced by participants in the early-modern economy.

Peter Fidler would have internalized all of this recent economic history as a way of life. For him, issues of trust and credit were largely economic issues bearing on individual reputation. For the native North Americans, individual reputation was strictly internal to the home group; it could not exist for strangers. Similarly, an individual making a pledge based on his word of honor was a sacred obligation for Fidler but no more than play acting for the native North Americans (this is not to deny them personal honor, just that their identity was as part of a group that did not include the Europeans, so there could be no person-to-person obligations between groups). The Natives had to rely on those within their group for their survival, so their interactions with the Europeans was as a group, and only as a group.

The money of account used in the fur trade was the dressed pelt of an adult beaver. When they talk about the cost or value of goods in MB (made beaver), they are talking about that value being made (translated) into so many beaver pelts. It is perfectly natural to both the Europeans and the Natives to use credit-based accounts as a means of exchange since most transactions on both continents did not use money as a medium of exchange much of the time. However, the Europeans issued credit to individual North Americans and expected them to behave within the bounds of honor in a European context. We can often read between the lines in Fidler's journals to see how the social context of Native obligations was at odds with this system of credit.

There are many occasions in Fidler's journals where a particular guide promises to take Fidler and crew to a particular place or by a certain route, only to apparently decide against the venture after going part way; claiming that he can no longer remember the route, or that he forgot that it was impassable, or some such excuse. This recurrent situation is vexing to the Europeans who regard it as a breach of trust between contracted parties. They cannot see that the individual Natives have no personal duty to contracts as such; that their loyalty lies with a collective that does not include the Europeans.

The reader of these journals should keep in mind the social contexts of both the emerging modernity and national identity of the Europeans, and the home-group identity of the North Americans, in addition to the clash of cultures as they travel and trade with one another. We can learn a great deal about the modern world in which we can comfortably move about in a city of strangers and make contracts freely by noting how these early-modern Europeans were adapting to this radical transformation in human relations. Fidler, the observer, imposes his own beliefs and biases on his narrative of both European and North American behavior. His accounts are impersonal enough to see the factual situation behind the

narrative, yet often intimate enough to infer the points of view that cause the described behaviors. There is a veritable banquet of sociological insight laying inside these stories of wilderness travel and adventure.